

Senior Dog Hind Leg Weakness: At-Home Exercise Checklist

For senior dogs showing mild to moderate hind leg weakness, wobbling, or stiffness.

Not a substitute for veterinary care. If your dog is suddenly unable to stand, in severe pain, or has lost bladder/bowel control, contact your vet or ER immediately.

Before You Start

Before beginning any exercise plan:

- ☐ Confirm with your vet that exercise is safe for your dog's condition.
 - ☐ Choose a non-slip area (rug, mat, grass, not slippery tile).
 - ☐ Have treats, water, and a calm space ready.
 - ☐ Keep sessions short (6–10 minutes) and gentle.
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Section 1: Safety & Red Flags

Stop immediately and call your vet if your dog:

- ☐ Cannot stand or walk on back legs
- ☐ Cries out, yelps, or is vicious when touched
- ☐ Collapses or legs give out completely
- ☐ Loses bladder or bowel control
- ☐ Has sudden severe back/neck pain, especially after jumping or falling

If you notice these, reduce intensity or pause exercises and contact your vet.

Section 2: Exercise Rules (Read Before Each Session)

Before each session, remember:

- **Frequency:** 2–3 short sessions per day (6–10 minutes each).
- **Intensity:** Mild effort, not exhaustion.

Your dog should be able to:

- ☐ Breathe comfortably
- ☐ Move without limping or crying
- ☐ Act normally the next day

Stop if you see:

- ☐ Whining, yelping, or growling
- ☐ Heavy panting, trembling, or very tense body
- ☐ Refusing to move or collapsing during the session

- ☐ Increased stiffness or lameness the next day
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Section 3: Core Exercises

Do these in a safe, non-slip area.

Exercise 1: Assisted Sit-to-Stand

Purpose: Strengthens hips, hind legs, and core.

- Place dog in a sitting position. Stand behind or beside them comfortably.
- Gently support chest and hindquarters (hands or rear-support harness).
- Encourage them to stand with a calm voice and a treat. Give light support as they rise.
- Praise them once standing, let them rest a few seconds. Gently guide back to sitting. **Reps:** Week 1 (3-5 reps), Week 2-3 (5-8 reps), Week 4+ (8-10 reps)

Exercise 2: Controlled Leash Walks

Purpose: Maintains muscle, improves circulation, builds confidence.

- Use a harness (not just a collar). Keep leash short and controlled.
- Walk slowly on grass, dirt, or non-slip pavement. Avoid steep hills and slippery surfaces. **Reps:** Week 1 (5 mins), Week 2-3 (7-10 mins), Week 4+ (Adjust based on comfort)

Exercise 3: Supported "Dancing" (Hip Extension & Balance)

Purpose: Activates hind end and improves balance.

- Stand in front of your dog, facing them. Gently lift their front paws a few inches off the ground.
- Keep your back straight and support their chest. Hold for 2–5 seconds, then gently lower. **Reps:** Week 1 (3 reps), Week 2-3 (4-6 reps), Week 4+ (6-8 reps)

Exercise 4: Step-Ups (Low Impact)

Purpose: Strengthens hind legs and improves coordination.

- Use a low, stable step. Place front paws on the step first, then encourage hind paws up.
- Support with hands or harness as needed. Step back down. **Reps:** Week 1 (3-5 reps), Week 2-3 (5-8 reps), Week 4+ (8-10 reps)

Exercise 5: Backward Steps

Purpose: Activates hind legs and core gently.

- Stand in front of your dog, facing them. Hold a treat near their nose.
- Gently encourage them to step backward a few steps. Keep movement slow and controlled. **Reps:** Week 1 (3-5 steps), Week 2-3 (5-8 steps), Week 4+ (8-10 steps)

Exercise 6: Balance Surface (Soft Mat or Cushion)

Purpose: Improves balance and strengthens hind legs with minimal impact.

- Place a soft mat or cushions on a non-slip floor. Guide your dog to stand on it.
- Support them with your hands or harness. Hold for 5–10 seconds, then step off. **Reps:** Week 1 (3 holds), Week 2-3 (4-5 holds), Week 4+ (6-8 holds)

Exercise 7: Gentle Massage / Range-of-Motion (if vet approves)

Purpose: Helps circulation and keeps joints moving gently.

- Gently stroke the leg from paw to hip, then back down.
- Very gently bend and straighten the hip and knee (if your dog allows). *Stop if they tense up, pull away, or seem uncomfortable.*



Section 4: Weekly Progress Tracker

Use this to track your dog's progress each week.

Week #: _____

- **Ease of rising from lying down (1–10):** _____
- **Number of steps before wobbling:** _____
- **How often they slip on floors:** [] Rare [] Sometimes [] Often
- **Pain signs (whining, panting, tension):** [] None [] Some [] Frequent
- **Energy level:** [] Low [] Medium [] High
- **Notes (what worked, what didn't):** _____



Section 5: Home Setup Quick Checklist

Make your home safer for your senior dog:

- ☐ Add non-slip rugs or mats on tile/wood floors.
- ☐ Limit or block stairs if they're unsafe.
- ☐ Use ramps for sofa/car if needed.
- ☐ Provide an orthopedic bed with easy access.
- ☐ Use a rear-support harness for walks and stairs.
- ☐ Raise food/water bowls slightly if that helps with neck/shoulder strain.



Section 6: Track This in the Pet Health Notes App

Want to track symptoms, exercises, and progress over time?

1. Download the Pet Health Notes app.
2. Create a profile for your senior dog.
3. Log: Hind leg weakness symptoms, exercise sessions, pain signs, and vet visits.
4. Export a report to bring to your vet.



Section 7: Questions to Ask Your Vet

Take this checklist to your vet and discuss:

- ☐ Does this look more orthopedic or neurologic?
 - ☐ Which joints/spinal segments are most affected?
 - ☐ What pain control plan is safest for my dog's age and labs?
 - ☐ Should we do X-rays? When would we consider advanced imaging?
 - ☐ Can we get a referral to a rehab/physical therapy clinic?
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